PLAINTEXT PRIVACY

Linux

Linux is the most privacy-respecting desktop OS available. This guide helps you choose the right distro and covers the most important post-install steps.

START HERE

Choose the right distro for your experience level

CRITICAL

`Download from official distro website`

Why it matters: The right distro makes the difference between a smooth transition and a frustrating one. Beginner-friendly distros like Linux Mint and Zorin OS are designed to feel familiar to Windows users while offering full Linux privacy benefits.

`Steps:`

1. `Linux Mint` - looks and feels like older Windows. Best choice for complete beginners switching from Windows. Download at `linuxmint.com`
2. `Zorin OS` - polished UI with Windows-like layout. Supports many Windows apps via compatibility layer. Download at `zorin.com`
3. `Ubuntu` - most widely used desktop Linux. Massive community support and documentation. Download at `ubuntu.com`
4. To try Linux without replacing your OS: use `Balena Etcher` to flash the ISO to a USB drive, then boot from the USB (hold F12 or Del on startup)
5. Note: Linux Mint and Zorin don't officially support Apple Silicon Macs - best on Intel hardware or as a Windows replacement

Enable full-disk encryption during installation

CRITICAL

`Available in the installer for all recommended distros`

Why it matters: Linux is only as secure as its encryption. Enable LUKS full-disk encryption during the installation wizard - it's a checkbox in the installer. This is much harder to add after the fact.

`Steps:`

1. During the installation wizard, look for `Encrypt the new Linux installation for security` or `Use LVM with encryption` - check it
2. Set a strong encryption passphrase - this is entered at boot before anything else loads
3. Store this passphrase somewhere physically secure - if you forget it, your data is unrecoverable

HIGH

Keep packages updated

HIGH

`Terminal: sudo apt update && sudo apt upgrade`

Why it matters: Linux security depends on keeping your kernel and packages up to date. Unlike Windows, updates rarely require a restart and are fast to apply.

`Steps:`

1. Open Terminal and run: `sudo apt update && sudo apt upgrade`
2. Or use the graphical Update Manager (comes with Mint and Ubuntu) - it shows available updates and lets you apply them with one click
3. Enable automatic security updates: `sudo apt install unattended-upgrades` then `sudo dpkg-reconfigure unattended-upgrades`

Enable UFW firewall

HIGH

`Terminal: sudo ufw enable`

Why it matters: UFW (Uncomplicated Firewall) is Linux's built-in firewall. It's installed on most Ubuntu-based distros but not enabled by default. One command turns it on and blocks unsolicited incoming connections.

`Steps:`

1. Open Terminal and run: `sudo ufw enable`
2. Verify it's active: `sudo ufw status` - you should see `Status: active`
3. UFW blocks all incoming connections by default while allowing outgoing - this is the right default for a personal computer

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